THE LAST DAY

It is August 24, 79 CE. Along the Vicolo dei Vettii, the citizens of Pompeii are talking, shopping, and doing their daily tasks. A black plume of ash rises from the mountain behind them. People are not quite sure what to make of it—should they be concerned? Pompeii has been shaken by earthquakes before but this feels very different.



1 Rising ash
The vast ash cloud shooting into the sky is the first warning of the deadly eruption to come.

2 Shop sign
Pompeii's shop signs were marked using carvings, such as this one representing a donkey.

3 Negotiation
Aulus Vettius Conviva is agreeing a price for repairing a fresco that was damaged in an earthquake.

4 Settlers from all over
This North African man is one of many people from outside Italy who make Pompeii their home.

5 Road crossing
Roman streets had raised stones, so people could cross the street without getting their feet wet.

6 Roof repairs
These tiles were broken in a recent earthquake. There is lots of work for repairmen in Pompeii.

7 Roman graffiti
Modern people weren't the first to graffiti. This writing begins "Secundus greets his Prima."

8 Bakery
Pompeii is home to at least 35 bakeries—it's easier to buy bread than to bake it at home.

9 Snack bar
Most people don't have their own kitchens. They buy food at snack bars, like this one.

10 Crash!
This enslaved person has dropped a pot of olive oil, a common ingredient in Roman cooking.

11 Dry pump
No water is coming from the pump. Earthquakes might have damaged the aqueduct.